Langston Hughes

Langston Hughes was an African American author. He believed his job was to celebrate the story of his people. He was born in Missouri on February 1, 1902. When his parents divorced, he lived with his grandmother. At 13, he joined his mother and her new husband. He wrote his first poems then. After high school, he spent some time in Mexico and a year at Columbia University. He took odd jobs to cover the bills. Working as a sailor, he traveled to Europe and Africa. His first book of poetry was published in 1926. Then, he returned to college, graduating from Lincoln University in 1929. Hughes was one of the founders of the cultural movement known as the Harlem Renaissance. He wrote innovative poetry that integrated jazz rhythms. He was also a successful playwright. After Hughes died on May 22, 1967, in New York, his home in Harlem became a landmark.

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Barack Obama

Barack Obama was born on August 4, 1961, in Hawaii. His parents were divorced in 1964. His mother later married a college student from Indonesia. The family moved to Jakarta when Obama was six. He went to school there until he was ten. In 1971, Barack returned to Hawaii and lived with his grandmother. After high school, he attended Occidental College in Los Angeles and then Columbia University in New York. In 1988, he entered Harvard Law School. He was elected to the Illinois Senate in 1996, where he served until he became a United States Senator in 2004. He left the Senate in 2008 when he was elected the 44th president of the United States. He was the first African American ever elected to that office.

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Frederick Douglass

Frederick Douglass was an important abolitionist. He was born a slave in 1818. When he was 20 years old, he escaped by pretending to be a sailor. He then married and started a family, educated himself, and became a brilliant speaker against slavery. He also spoke out about women's rights, participating in the first women's rights convention in Seneca Falls in 1848. His autobiography and his anti-slavery paper, *The North Star,* made him famous. He remained a major public figure after the Civil War (1861–1865). He died on February 20, 1895.

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Booker T. Washington

Booker T. Washington was born a slave in 1856. After the Civil War, he worked as a janitor to pay for his education at Hampton Institute in Virginia. He saw education as the key to creating a better life for blacks. In 1881, he founded the Tuskegee Normal and Industrial Institute in Tuskegee, Alabama. He became a well-known speaker and met with President Theodore Roosevelt and other top leaders. He urged blacks to rely more on their own economic skills and moral character than on direct political or legal action. He died on November 14, 1915.

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Harriet Tubman

Harriet Tubman was a conductor on the Underground Railroad, a secret network that helped slaves escape before the Civil War. Tubman was born on a Maryland plantation in about 1820. Both of her parents were slaves. She started doing housework when she was just seven years old. By the time she was 19, she was working beside men in the fields. In 1844, she married John Tubman, but she left him to escape in 1849. Safe in the North, she worked as a maid and saved money to help others get away. She made 19 trips over the secret route and led about 300 people to freedom. She also supported her parents and helped needy ex-slaves after the Civil War. She died on March 10, 1913.

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Sojourner Truth

Sojourner Truth was born Isabella Baumfree in 1797 as a slave in a Dutch settlement in the state of New York. She ran away from her last owner just months before New York ended slavery in 1828. In 1843, she claimed she had religious visions telling her to "travel up and down the land" preaching God's word. She changed her name to Sojourner Truth. Soon, she was speaking out against slavery. By the 1850s, she had become a powerful voice in the battle for women's rights and the abolition of slavery. She died on November 26, 1883.

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W. E. B. Du Bois

William Edward Burghardt Du Bois was an African American scholar. He was born in Massachusetts to a free family in 1868 and went to school with whites. When he moved to Tennessee to attend Fisk University, he experienced racism for the first time. He went on to become the first African American to earn a doctorate at Harvard University. He became a well-known activist and author, fighting for equal rights for blacks in all areas of life. In 1903, he published a collection of essays called *The Souls of Black Folk*. He was also one of the founders of the National Association for the Advancement of Colored People (NAACP) in 1909 and became editor of its magazine, *The Crisis*. He died on August 27, 1963, at the age of 95.

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Louis Armstrong

Louis Armstrong was a jazz trumpeter and singer. Friends and fans called him Satchmo, short for "satchel mouth." He was born in New Orleans on August 4, 1901. His family was poor, and as a child he did odd jobs for cash. He also got into trouble. In 1913, he was sent to a home for boys. There, he learned to play the cornet and joined the band. He had found his passion. Soon, he was listening to other musicians and learning from them. In 1924, he married a pianist he met in Chicago, Lil Hardin. He went on to tour America and Europe with big bands. He invented new musical styles that continue to inspire jazz musicians around the world. Armstrong died on July 6, 1971, in New York City.

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George Washington Carver

George Washington Carver was born a slave in Missouri around 1864. After the Civil War ended slavery in Missouri, Moses and Susan Carver raised and educated George and his brother. In 1896, he received a master's degree in agricultural science from Iowa State Agricultural College. He was the first black student at Iowa State. Booker T. Washington hired him to run the agricultural department at Tuskegee Institute. In time, Carver's research transformed agriculture in the South. His discoveries included some 300 different uses for the peanut and about 100 for the sweet potato. His inventions included plastics, paints, and dyes. Carver was one of the most famous African Americans of his time. He toured the country speaking and writing about the importance of agriculture. He died on January 5, 1943.

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Jesse Owens

Athlete Jesse Owens won four gold medals in the 1936 Summer Olympics in Berlin, Germany. He was born in 1913 as the son of a sharecropper. He overcame chronic childhood illnesses to become a star sprinter and long jumper in high school. While attending Ohio State University, he went on to win many national awards and even set records. This photo shows him in Berlin at the start of his record-breaking 200-meter race. What made his Olympic victories special was that he won them during Adolf Hitler's reign of Germany. Hitler expected Germany to sweep the Olympic Games and attacked the United States for allowing black athletes to compete. Owens won the most gold medals of any athlete. He died on March 31, 1980.

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Jackie Robinson

Jackie Robinson was born on January 31, 1919. He and his four siblings were raised by a single mother. He was a star athlete in high school and at the University of California. In 1945, Jackie Robinson started his baseball career in the Negro leagues. Black players had not been allowed in the major leagues since the 1880s. He started looking for a position in the majors. The general manager of the Brooklyn Dodgers, impressed by his skills, signed him up for one of their farm clubs. He warned Robinson that he would face abuse, and he was right, but for the young player, it was worth it. On April 15, 1947, at first base for the Dodgers, he became the first African American to play in a major league game. He went on to become the National League's Most Valuable Player and helped the Dodgers win the 1955 World Series. He died on October 24, 1972.

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Martin Luther King, Jr.

Dr. Martin Luther King, Jr., was a great civil rights leader. He was born on January 15, 1929. Like his father and grandfather, he was a Baptist minister. In 1955, he earned a doctorate in theology from Boston University. While in Boston, he met Coretta Scott, who became his wife. King's extraordinary speaking skills gave him the ability to connect with thousands of people and persuade them to protest peacefully. In December of 1955, he helped to lead the Montgomery Bus Boycott, a nonviolent protest. Someone bombed his house, but he urged protesters to remain peaceful. He continued to organize and lead nonviolent protests for civil rights. Sadly, King's own life ended in violence. On April 4, 1968, he was assassinated in Memphis by James Earl Ray. In 1986, Congress created a national holiday to celebrate his life.

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Malcolm X

Malcolm X, a leader in the Nation of Islam, called for blacks to fight racism by "any means necessary." This included armed self-defense and violence. His views came from a childhood filled with violent racism. He was born in 1925 in Omaha, Nebraska, to a homemaker mother and preacher father. In 1931, his father was killed, most likely by white supremicists. Malcolm X went on to became a minister and powerful speaker. For a time, he refused to work with white people. After he left the Nation of Islam in 1964, he did change his views about working with whites. Yet he and Martin Luther King, Jr., a peace activist, continued to disagree about nonviolence. Malcolm X was assassinated on February 21, 1965. He influenced those who used the slogan "Black Power" with the belief that blacks must rely on themselves to make their lives better.

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Sidney Poitier

Sidney Poitier was born on February 20, 1927, while his parents were visiting Miami, Florida. He grew up in the Bahamas, their home. After serving in the American army during World War II, he decided to become an actor. He joined a theater company in New York City. He landed his first movie role as a doctor in *No Way Out*. Many other movie acting and directing jobs followed, but he also continued to perform in plays. In 1955, he won a Tony award for his performance in *Raisin in the Sun*. His role in the film *Lilies of the Field* won the Oscar and the Golden Globe for best actor. Poitier has received many other honors, including the U.S. Presidential Medal of Freedom.

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Thurgood Marshall

The U.S. Supreme Court is a panel of nine judges, who serve for life. Thurgood Marshall was the first African American Supreme Court Justice. He was born in Maryland on July 2, 1908. After graduating from law school, he became the head lawyer for the National Association for the Advancement of Colored People (NAACP). In that position, he presented a case that changed the lives of millions of children. The case was *Brown v. Board of Education of Topeka*. The Supreme Court heard his arguments and decided that states could no longer have separate schools for blacks and whites. After President Johnson appointed Marshall to the Supreme Court in 1967, he continued to support equal rights. He served on the court until he was almost 83. He died on January 24, 1993.

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Rosa Parks

The story of Rosa Parks proves that one brave person really can change the world. She was born on February 4, 1913. In 1932, she married Raymond Parks, a barber. She became a seamstress. On December 1, 1955, she was riding the bus home from work. The driver moved the sign for the black section in the back of the bus to make more room in front for white passengers. He asked Mrs. Parks to move back. She refused. When she was arrested, the black community started a boycott that put an end to separate sections on buses and trains. Later on, Parks joined the NAACP. She served as secretary for the Montgomery Chapter until 1956. She also received many awards for her courage and service. Parks died in Detroit on October 24, 2005.

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Dr. Charles Drew

Charles Drew was born on June 3, 1904, in Washington, D.C. An athletic youth, Drew attended Amherst College on a sports scholarship. He went on to medical school at McGill University in Canada. After receiving a Rockefeller Fellowship in 1938, Drew developed a method to process and preserve plasma by drying it. Plasma can be stored longer than whole blood, which made the discovery a breakthrough for blood banks. Drew headed up several large-scale military blood drives, including "Blood for Britain" and the Red Cross Blood Bank. However, he was angered by the military's policy of segregating the blood of African Americans and resigned his position. Drew went on to continue his medical work and earned the highest honor from the NAACP. He died on April 1, 1950.

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Shirley Chisholm

Shirley Chisholm was born on November 30, 1924, in New York. Part of her childhood was spent in Barbados, her mother's homeland, and the rest in Brooklyn. After graduating from Brooklyn College in 1946, she taught nursery school. She met her husband while studying elementary education at Columbia University. She became active in politics through her work for New York City's day-care division. She represented her district in the state legislature from 1964 to 1968. In 1968, she was elected to the U.S. House of Representatives. In 1972, she tried to become the Democratic nominee for president. She won 152 delegates, but it wasn't enough. She continued her work in Congress until 1983. She worked for justice through writing and speaking until her death on January 1, 2005.

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John Mercer Langston

John Mercer Langston was born December 14, 1829, in Virginia. His mother was an emancipated slave and his father was a wealthy white planter. At the age of 14, he enrolled at Oberlin College in Ohio. He went on to earn a master's degree and become the first black lawyer in Ohio. He opened a respected law practice and was elected to positions in town government. Langston organized anti-slavery societies and helped slaves escape through the Underground Railroad. In 1864, he became the first president of the National Equal Rights League and campaigned for black voting rights. After the Civil War, he traveled throughout the South to support newly freed slaves. In 1888, he ran for a seat in the U.S. House of Representatives and became the first African American from Virginia elected to Congress. Langston died on November 15, 1897.

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Dred Scott

Dred Scott, a slave, was born about 1795. His master, Peter Blow, took him to St. Louis, Missouri. After Blow died, Scott was sold to Dr. John Emerson. Emerson took him to Illinois, which was a free state, and then to a fort in the Wisconsin Territory. Scott met Harriet Robinson, another slave, and they married. After two years, the army sent Dr. Emerson to Louisiana, where he married. After Emerson died in 1843, Scott sued Mrs. Emerson for his freedom. The case went to the Supreme Court. The Justices said Scott could not sue because African Americans were not citizens. The decision shocked many. It strengthened anti-slavery feelings in the North. The sons of Scott's original owner, Peter Blow, bought Scott and his wife and gave them their freedom. Scott died on September 17, 1858.

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Phillis Wheatley

Phillis Wheatley was born in 1753 in West Africa and was brought to Massachusetts on a slave ship in 1761. At about age seven, Wheatley was sold as a slave to a Boston family. They treated her well and educated her. She studied the Bible and admired several English poets. She became famous in 1770 with a poem on the death of evangelical preacher George Whitefield. She was the first African American poet and the first African American woman to publish a book. Her poems are filled with hope that all people can be saved by Christian teachings. Only rarely did she write about the sufferings of African slaves, as in this line: "Some view our sable race with scornful eye." She was granted freedom in 1778 and married, but then died in poverty on December 5, 1784.

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Marian Anderson

It was clear to everyone that Marian Anderson had a gift. Italian conductor Arturo Toscanini told her that "a voice like yours is heard only once in a hundred years." Marian Anderson was born February 27, 1897, in Philadelphia. She began singing in her church choir at a young age and her church congregation raised money so she could take regular singing lessons. On August 26, 1925, Anderson had her first formal performance at the New York Philharmonic. She went on to tour Europe during the 1930s. She became the first African American to perform with the New York Metropolitan Opera in 1955. Anderson received many honors, including being named delegate to the United Nations and earning the Nobel Peace Prize and a Grammy Award for Lifetime Achievement. She retired from singing in 1965 and died on April 8, 1993, at the age of 96.

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Ida B. Wells-Barnett

Ida B. Wells-Barnett was born a slave in Mississippi on July 16, 1862. When she was about six months old, the Emancipation Proclamation freed slaves, but life was still hard for her family. Ida had to drop out of school when her parents died of yellow fever. She cared for her brothers and sisters. At 18, she taught in a country school. In 1882, she moved in with an aunt in Tennessee, where she studied at Fisk University. After being forced to move to a special car for African Americans on a train ride, she was furious. Using the pen name "Iola," she wrote articles about race problems. As a teacher in Memphis, she protested conditions in black schools. She also worked to stop lynch mobs in the South. She died on March 25, 1931.

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Wilma Rudolph

Wilma Rudolph was born on June 23, 1940, in Tennessee. She was the 20th in a family of 22 children. As a child, she had polio. The doctor said she would never walk again. Her mother took her to a special hospital for therapy. At first she walked with metal braces. Then, she did special exercises at home. By the time she was 12, she could walk normally. In high school, she became a basketball star. A track coach from Tennessee State University offered her training at a sports camp and a college scholarship. At age 16, she won a bronze medal at the 1956 Olympics. Four years later, she became the first American woman to win three Olympic gold medals. She later wrote her autobiography, which was turned into a TV movie, and worked as a teacher and track coach. She died on November 12, 1994.

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